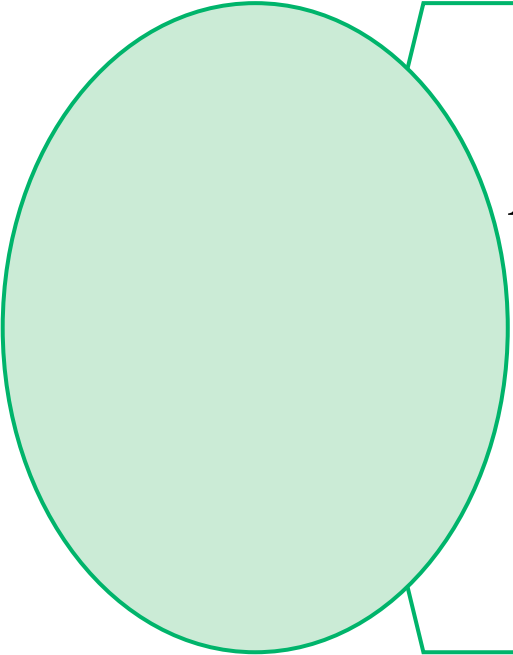

Technical and Business Writing

Course instructor: Ms. Mariam Aftab

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What is cover letter?



A cover letter is a document sent with your resume to provide additional information on your skills and experience.

Foundations

Identify your key strengths and accomplishment

Research the company to see (and be able to explain) how you will be an asset.

Header

A cover letter should begin with both you and the employer's contact information (name, address, phone number, email) followed by the date. If this is an email rather than an actual letter, include your contact information at the end of the letter, after your signature.

Salutation

Begin your cover letter salutation with "Dr./Mr./Ms. Last Name." If you are unsure if your contact is male or female, you can write out their full name. If you do not know the employer's last name, simply write, "Dear Hiring Manager."

Cover Letter Formats

Standard Business Paragraph Gives all of your information in a cordial letter style

Dr. John Smith
123 Broadway
City, State 12345
(000) 111-1111

January 30, 2012

Mrs. Jane Smith
Recruitment Officer
The Corporation
123 Pleasant Lane
City, State 12345

Dear Mrs. Smith,

PARAGRAPH ONE: State the reason for the letter, name the position or type of work you are applying for and identify the source from which you learned of the opening (i.e. career development center, newspaper, employment service, personal contact).

PARAGRAPH TWO: Indicate why you are interested in the position, the company, its products, services - above all, stress what you can do for the employer. If you are a recent graduate, explain how your academic background makes you a qualified candidate for the position. If you have practical work experience, point out specific achievements or unique qualifications. Try not to repeat the same information the reader will find in the resume. Refer the reader to the enclosed resume or application which summarizes your qualifications, training, and experiences. The purpose of this section is to strengthen your resume by providing details which bring your experiences to life.

PARAGRAPH THREE: Request a personal interview and indicate your flexibility as to the time and place. Repeat your phone number in the letter and offer assistance to help in a speedy response. For example, state that you will be in the city where the company is located on a certain date and would like to set up an interview. Alternatively, state that you will call on a certain date to set up an interview. End the letter by thanking the employer for taking time to consider your credentials.

Sincerely yours,

John Smith
encl: Curriculum vitae, employment form

Cover Letter Formats

Skills and Qualification Comparison
Highlights what the employer is looking for
and how you can fill that need

Elizabeth Befus

Application for Technical Writer
June 26, 2008

Greeting

I'm pleased to apply to your job opening for a **Technical Writer**. My resume and writing samples are attached, and below are the highlights of how my experience matches your job requirements.

You need someone who...	I have...
Has 5 years hands-on experience in technical writing applications.	Nearly 5 years experience in technical writing across a wide variety of document types (including technical reports, proposals, presentations, web copy, white papers, manuals, newsletters, and more).
Has experience writing winning proposals or grants.	Experience writing successful 1000 proposals and proposals to Microsoft teams. I voluntarily spent 6 months evaluating my company's past 200 1000 proposals to determine winning factors and train engineers on those factors, which dramatically improved our proposal win rate the next proposal round (51 more wins than expected).
Can work effectively within a technical team.	Contributed extensively to technical teams of software, mechanical, and electrical engineers and other subject matter experts since 2004.
Can work independently to track and manage multiple proposals and other documents to meet internal and external deadlines.	Worked with engineers to successfully deliver 1000 proposals by various government deadlines several times a year. Most recently, I've managed the workload of a team of 20 technical writers and graphic designers working on hundreds of Microsoft deliverables with varying deadlines.
Can create graphics to explain technical concepts.	Experience creating simple technical graphics for 1000 proposals and other document types (reports, presentations, brochures, and web).
Has expertise in Microsoft Office, including PowerPoint and Word.	A power user level of expertise in Microsoft PowerPoint (master slides, animation, innovative layouts) and in Microsoft Word (styles, track changes, formatting, macros, headers/footers, references, and more).
Has a Bachelor's degree in English or Technical Communications.	A recent Master's degree in Technical Communication.
Has experience with InDesign, Photoshop, and FrameMaker.	Used InDesign and FrameMaker to produce manuals, brochures, and newsletters. Used Photoshop extensively to manipulate/rep graphics and prepare them for the web.

I'm currently employed by a Microsoft vendor (4010000, Inc.) that creates technical and marketing content for emerging Microsoft technologies but am available immediately for a phone or in-person interview to discuss my qualifications further. I look forward to hearing from you.

Closes

Elizabeth Befus
Phone: (712) 556-5588
E-mail: elizabeth@beful.com

Cover Letter Formats

Bulleted Center Paragraph
Puts more focus on the information
you want the reader to remember

John Smith
404-555-1212 33 Windluff Street, Duluth, GA 30098 johnsmith@retailservice.com

Date:

Company Name
Attn: Director
123 Smart Street
Atlanta, GA 30308

Dear Hiring Manager:

Visionary marketing...Fearless organizational planning...Positive community accountability.

Helping to implement Operation Legacy, through the Economic and Business Development division of Georgia Power, is only the first of my many years' experience developing relationships that benefit communities, local, public, and professional. I have worked tirelessly to craft powerful marketing tools that communicate the benefits of technologically innovative products and services. I wish to bring my passion for the state of Georgia, my network of rising and influential professionals and policymakers, and powerful marketing expertise to Electric Cities of Georgia's Economic Development Council.

As a marketing executive, I have spearheaded numerous critical projects that led to rapid business development and sales growth:

- Enterprise-wide marketing plan development, including budgeting—for Big Marketing, Need to Know Marketing, Strategic Business, and Atlanta Endorsers University;
- Using data mining techniques to improve organizational strengths and create community outreach—for the Economic and Business Development division of The Power Company;
- Strategic and financial planning—with The List I achieved 55% revenue growth in just one year;
- Brand development—with Big Marketing and Need to Know Marketing, created a unified sales, marketing, and public relations message and execution (print, online, interpersonal) and encouraged each team to contribute according to this corporate image.

Having built marketing departments, brand identities, missions, and teams in the corporate world, I want to return to economic development to lend my strength and skills to building communities and shaping public development projects. If your organization is looking for a results-oriented marketing executive with an enthusiasm for Georgia and her future, I would be interested in speaking with you to discuss the value that my experience can deliver. I can be reached in confidence at the above telephone number or email address. I look forward to hearing from you.

With best regards,

John Smith

Enclosure: Resume

A cover letter should
expand, not DUPLICATE your resume

Explain why you're interested in their organization

Identify your most relevant skills/experiences

Express interest and knowledge about the position and company

The opening: Why I am writing to you

- State the position you are applying for, how you found out about it, and ask for consideration based on your skills and experiences you have to offer.
- If you were referred by someone (ie: someone you know at the company, a recruiter you met at a career fair, etc) state that here.
- Make a general statement summarizing what qualifies you most for the job.

Example:

I am excited to submit my application for the Training Specialist position I saw listed in Handshake. I am confident that my relevant education, experience and skills related to this position merit your consideration.

The core paragraph: Why I am the best candidate

- Build a direct connection between the company's needs and your background and skills. Stress what you have to offer, avoid talking about what you want from them.
- Identify those parts of your experience that will interest THIS employer (refer to the job description if possible).
- Draw attention to relevant course work, special projects and campus activities if they show direct relationship to this position.

The core paragraph: Why I am the best candidate

Example:

As you can see on my resumé, I will complete my bachelor's degree in Business Administration at UC Berkeley in May 2026. While this degree has provided me with a strong background in many aspects of business, it has also given me the opportunity to demonstrate my abilities through practical experience. As a Training Department Intern with UCSF, I was responsible for a new computer software education program. This project allowed me to develop and refine my training and organizational skills while designing a program to teach basic software applications to users with limited experience working with computers. The success of this program has been so overwhelming that the department has integrated it into their new staff training course.

The closing paragraph

- Restate your interest in this position and how your unique qualifications fit the position.
- Request an interview, or tell the reader that you will contact them soon in order to schedule a mutually convenient time to meet.
- Thank the reader for his/her time and consideration.

Example:

Although the enclosed resumé thoroughly outlines my education and experience, I would appreciate the opportunity to demonstrate in an interview my knowledge of employee training and development, initiative, and interpersonal skills. You can contact me at _____ to set up an interview. I look forward to hearing from you soon.